

DA CAPO

Get your scores out of Finale

User guide ▪ version 0.1.0

Da capo: "from the beginning", in music.

1. Score folders **2.** Working folder **3.** Finale **4.** Start

Windows ▪ macOS ▪ Linux

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1 Why Da Capo

Finale has not been developed since 2024. It still works, but no update will ever repair it if Windows breaks it one day. Its `.mus` and `.musx` files **only open in Finale**. The way out is called **MusicXML**: an open format read by MuseScore Studio (free), Dorico and Sibelius.

Finale can export a score to MusicXML, but one at a time. With hundreds of scores, that means days of clicking. **Da Capo does the clicking for you**, score after score, while you do something else — and checks the result.

1. Find	every Finale score in the chosen folders, subfolders included.
2. Copy	each one into the working folder, copy checked byte for byte.
3. Export	Finale opens each *copy*, exports it to MusicXML (and a reference PDF), closes it.
4. Check	every MusicXML is read back: parts, bars, notes, lyrics, dynamics.
5. Prepare	every MusicXML becomes a MuseScore score (`.mscz`) + a PDF to compare.
6. Report	`rapport.html`: what worked, what failed, what deserves a look.

Your scores are safe

- The original files are **never opened or modified**: Finale only sees copies.
- The copies are checked (SHA-256 fingerprint) and made read-only.
- Nothing is sent over the Internet: everything happens on your computer.

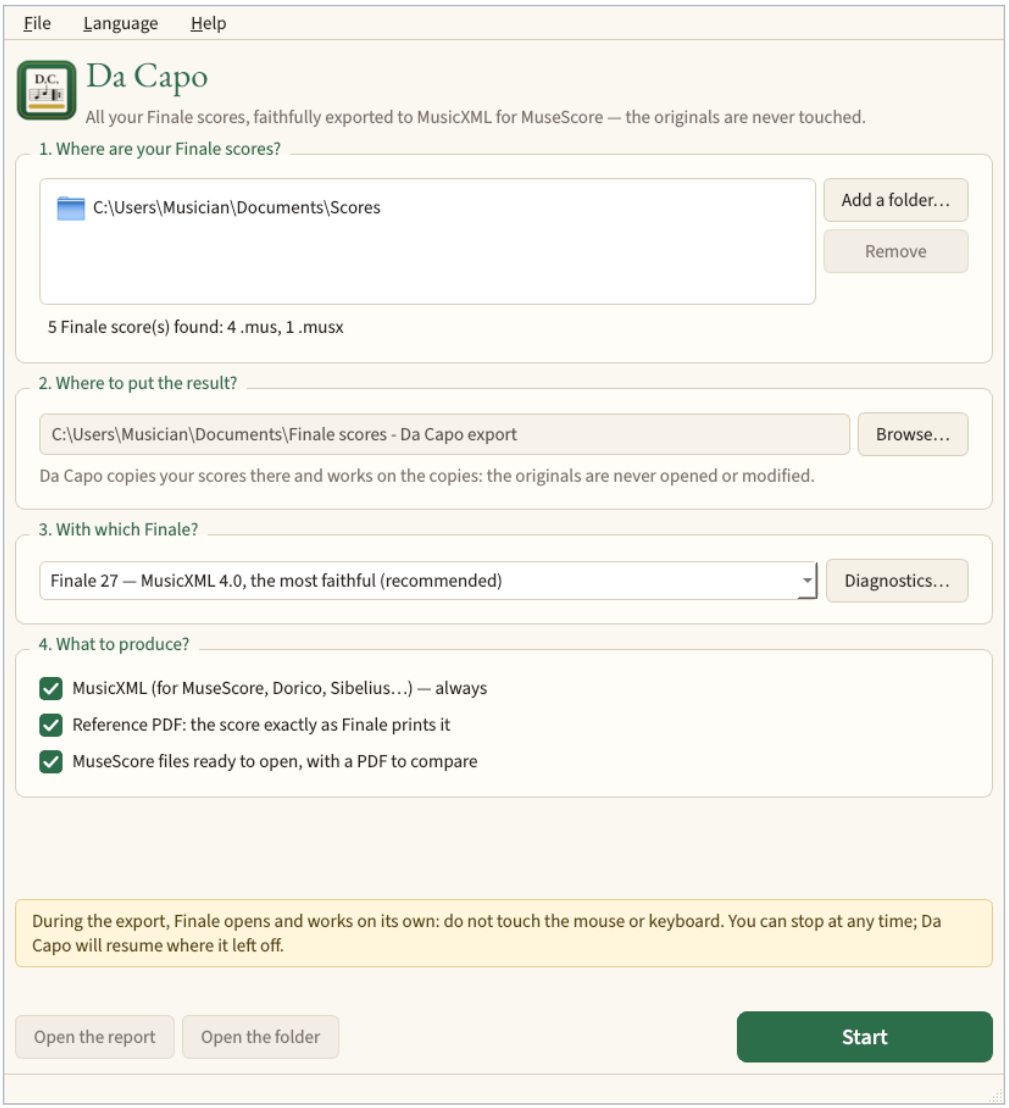
2 Before you start

1. **Install Da Capo**: `DaCapo-Setup.exe` on Windows (no administrator password). On first launch, Windows may show "Windows protected your PC": **More info** → **Run anyway**.
2. **Install MuseScore Studio** (optional but recommended) from `musescore.org` — not `musescore.com`, a partly paid sheet-music site. The software is free.
3. **Open the Finale that Da Capo will use once by hand**, especially if it is never used: answer what it asks on first launch (authorisation, update, welcome window), then **close it**.
4. **Before Finale 25**, the reference PDF goes through the free virtual printer **CutePDF Writer**: check that it is installed.

Good to know

If several Finale versions are installed, Da Capo suggests the most recent: it opens files from older versions without trouble and writes a much more faithful MusicXML (version 4.0 for Finale 27, versus a "basic MusicXML" for Finale 2003 to 2010).

3 The four steps



1. Where are your Finale scores?
Add a folder…, or drag the folder from Explorer. All subfolders are searched. Da Capo immediately counts the scores found (`.mus` up to Finale 2011, `.musx` after). Finale's backup copies ("Backup of…") are ignored.

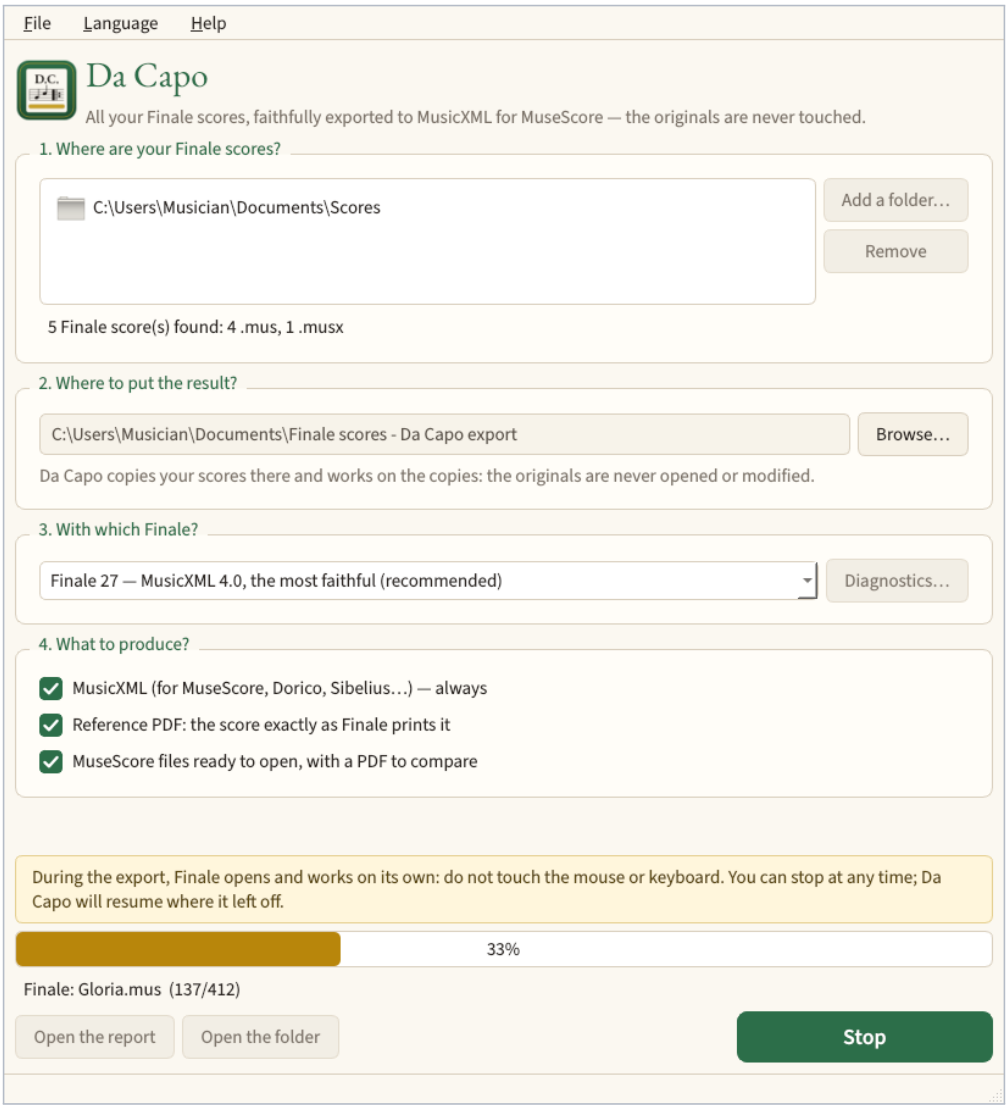
2. Where to put the result?
An empty folder, on a disk with room to spare (allow three to four times the size of the scores). Everything goes there, in the same tree as your original folders.

3. With which Finale?
The most recent is suggested and recommended. The first time, click **Diagnostics…** (section 8).

4. What to produce?
MusicXML, always. The **reference PDF**: the score exactly as Finale prints it — your yardstick for checking, and an archive that will always open. **MuseScore files**, if MuseScore Studio is installed.

Then click **Start**.

4 During the export



Finale opens and works on its own: you can see it open each score, export, close. **Do not touch the mouse or keyboard**: a click at the wrong moment would divert a dialog box. Allow from a few seconds to a minute per score; for several hundred, start in the evening and let it run overnight. The computer does not go to sleep.

- **Stop** finishes the current score, then stops cleanly.
- The button then becomes **Resume**: Da Capo skips everything already done. Even after a power cut, it only redoes the score that was in progress.
- If Finale shows a message (old file to convert, missing font…), Da Capo reads it, records it in the report, then closes it. To “Save changes?”, it always answers **No**.
- If Finale stops responding, Da Capo stops it, restarts it and moves on to the next score; the stubborn score is marked as failed and will be retried on resume.

5 The working folder

`originaux/`	the copies of your scores, read-only
`musicxml/`	the MusicXML files exported by Finale — keep them safe
`pdf-finale/`	the reference PDFs
`musescore/`	the MuseScore scores (`.mscz`) and their PDF
`rapport.html`	the report, to open in a web browser
`_dacapo/`	the log used to resume, and the diagnostics record

The whole folder can be moved or copied (to a backup disk, for example): the report's links follow.

6 The report

Open the report shows a page with, at the top, the summary (scores, MusicXML, PDF, MuseScore, failures), then one line per score:

red	the export failed; the reason is written (and Finale's messages)
orange	exported, but worth checking: empty score, Finale message during the export
green	all went well

For each score: the number of parts, bars and notes found in the MusicXML, and links to every file produced.

7 Checking a score

Open the **reference PDF** (Finale) and the **MuseScore PDF** side by side. Notes, rhythms, lyrics, dynamics and parts come through MusicXML well. What often needs touching up in MuseScore:

- the **layout**: system and page breaks, spacing, staff size;
- **custom expressions** and rare symbols, special music fonts;
- the **shape of slurs** and the fine position of text;
- anything that only concerns Finale's audio playback (Human Playback).

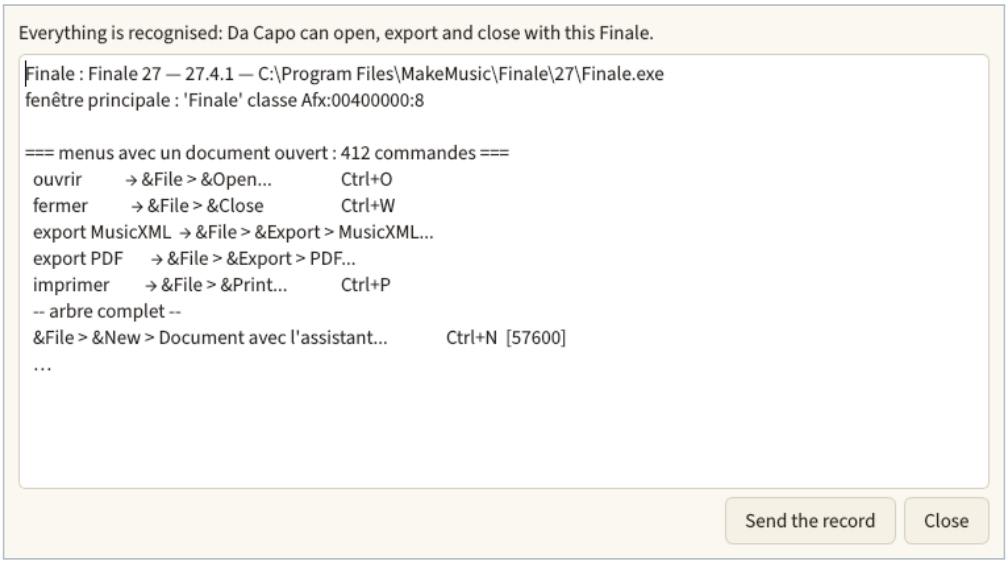
Start with the scores you still use; the others stay archived in three copies (original, MusicXML, PDF).

Caution

Keep the original `.mus` files and the copies in the working folder. One day, a better converter may redo the export from them.

8 Diagnostics

Each Finale version arranges its commands a little differently. Da Capo finds them by name, in English and in French. The **Diagnostics. . .** button checks this on your computer: it opens Finale with a copy of one score, records its menus and windows, then closes everything, without changing anything.



If everything is recognised, you are ready. Otherwise, **Send the record** sends it to the developer, who will adapt Da Capo to your Finale; the record is also saved in `_dacapo`.

9 Common problems

Message	What to do
Finale does not start	Open it once by hand (authorisation, update), close it, try again.
Command not found in Finale's menus	Run a diagnostic and send it.
CutePDF Writer printer not found	Install it (free), or untick the reference PDF.
Finale did not open the score in time	Damaged or very large file: open it by hand in Finale to see.
MuseScore took too long	Open the MusicXML directly in MuseScore.

10 Updates and privacy

At startup, Da Capo quietly checks for a new version and offers to install it. With your consent, a report is sent if it runs into a problem: program and system versions, the error; your file names and user name are hidden. No score is ever sent.

On macOS and Linux, Finale cannot be driven: Da Capo copies the scores, checks MusicXML files exported elsewhere and prepares the MuseScore files.

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